

Origins of Chinese Herbal Medicine

The development of Chinese herbal medicine was a long and gradual process. Primitive man, in the search for food from plants and by hunting animals, discovered medicinal substances. The accumulation of experiences during this search eventually developed into the earliest knowledge of Chinese medicine.

"Doctor" Recorded in Written History

The term "doctor" was first recorded in a Chinese history book dating back to 1066-771 B.C.

- *Shi Jing* (诗经) recorded Chinese herbs in 221 B.C.
- *Shan Hai Jing* (山海经) recorded over 100 animal or botanical herbal substances.

Divine Farmer's Classic of Materia Medica (Shen Nong Ben Cao Jing)

- The earliest extant treatise on Chinese medicine and herbs.
- Written during the Eastern (later) Han Dynasty (A.D. 25-220).
- Composed of 3 volumes.
- Lists 365 herbal substances (252 botanical, 45 mineral, 67 zoological).
- Introduced key concepts:
 - Temperature (*Si Qi* 四气).
 - Taste (*Wu Wei* 五味).
 - Toxicity.
 - Medicinal action of each herb.

Development of the Materia Medica

Tang Dynasty 618-907 CE

- *Tang Materia Medica* (唐本草) was published under the Tang government in 659 CE.
- Contained 844 herbs.
- The first illustrated materia medica.

Song Dynasty 960-1279 CE

- *Tai Ping Hui Min He Ji Ju Fang* (和剂局方).
- Developed the concepts of Eighteen Incompatibilities and Nineteen Antagonisms.

Ming Dynasty 1368-1644 CE

- Li Shi Zhen (1518-1593 CE), China's most celebrated herbalist:
 - Started practice in 1542.
 - Traveled widely, collecting and tasting herbs.
 - Took 27 years to write a monumental book.
 - Includes 1,892 individual herbal substances, 11,000 illustrations, and over 10,000 herbal formulas.

Review Questions

1. Who wrote the earliest extant treatise in Chinese medicine, and what is the name of the book?
2. How many herbs were recorded in the *Shen Nong Ben Cao Jing*? What key concepts were introduced?
3. Who completed a monumental Materia Medica, and how long did it take to complete it?
4. What is the name of this book?

Processing and Preparing Herbal Substances

Purpose

- To eliminate or decrease toxins, side effects, or the intensity of an herbal substance.
- To modify the actions of herbs to fit specific clinical conditions.
- To ease storage.
- To clean and prepare herbs for medicinal use.

Methods of Processing and Preparing

1. Mechanical Methods

- Cleaning, sorting, sifting, scraping, peeling, slicing, and winnowing.

2. Methods Using Water

- 润 (Moistening): Softening the herb before slicing.
- 漂 (Soaking): Washing herbs to remove unwanted properties.
- 水飞 (Aqueous Trituration): Grinding minerals with water until reduced to a fine powder.

3. Methods Using Fire

- Dry-frying (炒 chao).
 1. Dry the herbs for storage or to more easily break them down to small pieces.
 2. Dirt and wheat can be used to alter the actions of herbs.
- Frying with liquids (炙 zhi).
 1. Honey: tonifies and moisturizes
 2. Wine: Invigorates blood and alleviates pain
 3. Ginger: Antidote; warms and soothes the stomach
 4. Vinegar: smooths the liver and alleviates pain
 5. Salt: Tonifies the kidneys
- Calcining (煨 duan).
 1. Adds astringent action, rendering the substance brittle and easy to pulverize.
 2. Usually applied to minerals and shells.
- Roasting in ashes (煨 wei).

1. Wrap the herb in moistened paper, paste or mud and heat it in hot cinders.
- Dry curing or baking (焙 *bei*, 烘 *hong*).
 1. Use slow, mild heat to avoid charring the herb.

4. Methods Using Both Heat and Water

- Boiling (煮 *zhu*).
- Steaming (蒸 *zheng*).
- Quenching (淬 *cui*).
- Simmering (熬 *ao*).

Decoctions (汤 *tang*)

- The most common form of traditional Chinese medicine preparation in China.
- Made in ceramic or earthenware pots.
- Water is the primary solvent; wine and vinegar can also be used as solvents.
- **Types of Heat:**
 - Military Fire (武火 *wu huo*): High flame.
 - Civilian Fire (文火 *wen huo*): Low flame.

Cooking Method of Decoction

1. Soak the herbs for 30 minutes to 1 hour.
2. Once boiling, reduce the heat.
3. Avoid lifting the lid frequently.
4. Most formulas are cooked for 20–30 minutes.
 - Formulas that release the exterior or contain aromatic herbs: Cook for 15–20 minutes.
 - Tonic or cloying herbs: Cook for 45–60 minutes.
5. Decoct the herbs twice.
6. Decoctions are typically consumed warm, twice a day.

Special Considerations for Decoction

- **Decocted First (先煎 *xian jian*):**
 - Toxic herbs: Cook for 30–45 minutes.
 - Minerals and shells: Cook for 20–30 minutes.
- **Decocted in Gauze (包煎 *bao jian*):**
 - Herbs with cilia (fine, hair-like structures), small seeds, or certain minerals should be wrapped in gauze or cheesecloth.
- **Separately Decocted or Simmered (单煎 *dan jian*):**

- Rare or expensive herbs may require a separate decoction for up to 2–3 hours to achieve maximum potency. They are often sliced very thin and then cooked in a double boiler.
- **Dissolved in Strained Decoction** (溶化 *rong hua* / 烱化 *yang hua*):
 - Sticky or viscous substances should be dissolved in a small amount of the strained decoction in a small bowl and then added back to the strained decoction, stirring it in.
- **Taken with Strained Decoction** (冲服 *chong fu*):
 - Expensive aromatic substances should not be heated at all or boiled. Grind them into powder and consume with the decoction or warm water.

Review Questions

1. How do honey, wine, vinegar, and salt affect the medicinal actions of herbs?
2. What special treatment is needed for certain herbs during the decoction process?

Characteristics of Chinese Herbal Medicine

One of the strengths of Chinese Herbal Medicine (CHM) lies in its ability to prescribe unique formulas based on a precise understanding of the symptom pattern and the nature and properties of individual herbs. This approach enables the formulation of a prescription that addresses specific symptom patterns by utilizing herbs with tailored characteristics and actions.

Characteristics refer to:

- Thermal property (四气 *si qi*).
- Taste (五味 *wu wei*).
- Direction (升降浮沉 *sheng jiang fu chen*).
- Channel affiliation (归经 *gui jing*).
- Toxicity (毒性 *du xing*), if any.

Thermal Property (四气 *si qi*)

- Cold (寒 *han*). "Cold diseases must be warmed."
- Cool (凉 *liang*).
- Hot (热 *re*): "Hot diseases must be cooled."
- Warm (温 *wen*):
- Neutral (平 *ping*).

Taste (五味 *wu wei*)

- **Acrid**, aka Pungent (辛 *xin*):

- Actions:
 - Disperses outward, induces sweating (diaphoresis), dispels exterior pathogenic factors, and promotes the movement of Qi and blood.
- Indications:
 - External pathogenic influence
 - Qi and blood stagnation
- **Sweet** (甘 *gan*):
 - Actions:
 - Tonifies deficiency, harmonizes the Middle Jiao, and moderates harsh effects of other herbs.
 - Moderates pain
 - Indications:
 - Deficiency
 - Pain
- **Sour** (酸 *suan*):
 - Actions:
 - Stabilizes and binds, reduces or prevents body fluid loss, and relieves muscle spasms.
 - Indications:
 - For treating loss of body fluids
 - Muscle spasms and cramps
- **Astringent** (涩 *se*):
 - Actions:
 - Stabilizes and binds, reduces or prevents body fluid loss.
 - Indications:
 - Perspiration, diarrhea, bleeding, leukorrhea, urinary incontinence, enuresis, spermatorrhea, and nocturnal emission.
- **Bitter** (苦 *ku*):
 - Actions:
 - Purges and is downward draining, descends inappropriately rising Lung Qi, eliminates heat, and dries dampness.
 - Indications:
 - Constipation, wheezing or coughing, internal heat, dampness (both cold damp & damp heat)
- **Salty** (咸 *xian*):
 - Actions:
 - Softens hardness, purges excess, and facilitates the herbs to enter the Kidney.
 - Indications:
 - Scrofula, enlarged thyroid and nodules
 - Constipation
- **Bland** (淡 *dan*):
 - Actions:

- Leaches out dampness and promotes urination.
- Indications:
 - Edmea and difficult urination

Direction (升降浮沉 sheng jiang fu chen)

- Upward (升 sheng), Downward (降 jiang), Outward (浮 fu), Inward (沉 chen).

Directions and properties are connected

- Herbs with acrid, sweet, or hot properties tend to go upward and outward.
- Herbs with sour, bitter, salty, or cold properties move downward and inward.
- Direction can be affected by special treatment of the herbs, such as preparing with wine, ginger, vinegar, or salt.

Channel Affiliation (归经 gui jing)

- Refers to the specific function and indications of herbs, such as *Xing Ren* for the Lung and *Bu Gu Zhi* for treating diarrhea due to Spleen and Kidney deficiency.

Toxicity (毒性 du xing)

- Some herbs have toxic effects if not used properly. Most herbs are safe when used correctly and within recommended doses.

Herb-to-Herb Interactions

Seven Features

1. **Dan Xing 单行** (Single Effect): Using a single herb for a simple condition.
 - Huang Qin treats cough due to mild Lung Heat
2. **Xiang Xu 相须** (Mutual Accentuation): Herbs with similar functions enhance the overall therapeutic effect.
 - Shi Gao + Zhi Mu
 - Da Huang + Mang Xiao
3. **Xiang Shi 相使** (Mutual Enhancement): Herbs with different functions enhance each other's properties.
 - Fu Ling + Huang Qi
 - Huang Qin + Da Huang
4. **Xiang Wei 相畏** (Mutual Counteraction): One herb neutralizes or minimizes the toxic aspect of another.
 - Sheng Jiang + Ban Xia

- Sheng Jiang + Tian Nan Xing
- 5. **Xiang Sha 相杀** (Mutual Suppression): One herb suppresses the unwanted side effects of another.
 - Sheng Jiang + Ban Xia
 - Sheng Jiang + Tian Nan Xing
- 6. **Xiang Wu 相恶** (Mutual Antagonism): One herb diminishes the desired effect of another.
 - Ren Shen + Lai Fu Zi
- 7. **Xiang Fan 相反** (Mutual Incompatibility): Certain two herb combinations lead to adverse effects or side reactions.
 - Eighteen Incompatibilities
 - Nineteen Antagonisms (Counteractions)

Cautions and Contraindications:

Eighteen Incompatibles

- *Gan Cao* is incompatible with:
 - *Gan Sui, Da Ji, Hai Zao, Yuan Hua*
- *Wu Tou* is incompatible with:
 - *Bei Mu, Gua Lou, Ban Xia, Bai Lian, Bai Ji*
- *Li Lu* is incompatible with:
 - *Ren Shen, Sha Shen, Dan Shen, Ku Shen, Xi Xin, Bai Shao*

Nineteen Antagonisms

1. Liu Huang antagonizes Po Xiao
2. Shui Yin antagonizes Pi Shuang
3. Lang Du antagonizes Mi Tou Seng
4. Ba Dou antagonizes Qian Niu Zi
5. Ya Xiao antagonizes San Leng
6. Ding Xiang antagonizes Yu Jin
7. Wu Tou antagonizes Xi Jiao
8. Ren Shen antagonizes Wu Ling Zhi
9. Rou Gui antagonizes Chi Shi Zhi

Use of Herbs During Pregnancy

As a general rule, herbs with potent effects to regulate qi, move blood or drain downward should be avoided during pregnancy. These herbs are classified as contraindicated or for use with caution in the treatment of pregnant women.

Dietary Consideration

Foods that are cold, raw, greasy, rotten, or spoiled, and other foods that are difficult to digest, should be avoided when taking herbal medicines.

1. Chang Shan (Radix Dichroae)—no onion
2. Sheng or Shu Di Huang, He Shou Wu - no garlic or onion
3. Bo He – no crab
4. Fu Ling – no vinegar
5. Cong Bai (green onion)- no Honey

Measurement and Dosing

- 1 Liang = 30 g
- 1 Qian = 3 g
- 1 Fen = 0.3 g
- 5-10 g is a common dosage for most single herbs in a formula. That is the daily dose for an adult of average height and weight when using dry herbs. Some herbs can be used at higher doses of 15-30 g.

Measurement and Dosing

- Use ¼ of the adult dosage for children 5 years old or under.
- Use ½ of the adult dosage for children 6 years or older.
- Patients with a weak constitution need to be given low doses of herbs.
- Use a smaller dosage with light herbs.
- Use a bigger dosage with heavy herbs.

Common Names in Chinese Herbal Medicine

1. 子 zǐ seed, small things
2. 花 huā flower
3. 草 cǎo grass
4. 枝 zhī twig, branch
5. 叶 yè leaf
6. 皮 pí skin

7. 根 gēn root
 8. 仁 rén Seed, kernel
 9. 藤 téng vine
 10. 要药 Yao Yao: important herbal medicine
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Review Questions

1. What are the actions and indications of the four Qi and five tastes?
2. How does the direction of an herb relate to its clinical indication?
3. Review the meaning of the Seven Features.
4. Memorize the Eighteen Incompatibles and Nineteen Antagonisms.
5. What general cautions should be observed when using Chinese herbs during pregnancy?
6. Review the common names of herbs used in Chinese Herbal Medicine.